

Strongest earthquakes since 1900

- 1 Valdivia, Chile—May 22, 1960**
This earthquake measured 9.5 in magnitude. It killed 1,655 people and caused a tsunami that hit Japan, the Philippines, and the US.
- 2 Prince William Sound, Alaska—1964**
This 9.2-magnitude earthquake hit Alaska on March 27. While it killed 15 people, it caused a tsunami that killed another 113.
- 3 Indian Ocean—December 26, 2004**
Occurring at sea, this 9.1-magnitude earthquake caused a tsunami that killed 227,898 people and affected 1.7 million more.
- 4 Kamchatka, Russia—November 4, 1952**
This 9.0-magnitude earthquake sent a tsunami across the Pacific. In Hawaii, no human lives were lost, but six cows died.
- 5 Tohoku, Japan—March 11, 2011**
This 9.0-magnitude earthquake and tsunami killed more than 15,000 people and destroyed a nuclear power plant.

KEY

Earthquakes are marked on this map according to their strength, or magnitude. An earthquake with a magnitude of 9.0 makes ten times larger seismic waves than an 8.0-magnitude earthquake.

THE LAST 100 YEARS

- Magnitude < 7.0
- 7.0–7.5
- 7.5–8.0
- Greater than 8.0

THROUGHOUT HISTORY

- Strongest on record
- Deadliest on record

Earthquakes

Most earthquake zones are at the edges of the tectonic plates that make up Earth's crust. When the plates press against each other, the pressure builds until the plates move with a jerk, sending out a shock called a seismic wave.